Leading for Psychological Safety

What leaders can do every day to make it safe to speak up, ask for help and admit mistakes, without lowering the bar.

Lead the Organisation · Inspired by Amy Edmondson's Work · Set the Stage · Invite · Respond

LEADER _____

DATE _____

1 Set the Stage

FRAME THE WORK

Say the work is uncertain and needs everyone's input. Be open that you don't have all the answers.

DO

- ✓ Explain why each person's view matters
- ✓ Name the risks and unknowns out loud
- ✓ Share a mistake of your own

SAY

"This is new for all of us."

"I could be wrong about this."

2 Invite Participation

ASK, THEN LISTEN

Ask genuine questions and build ways for people to contribute, especially the quiet ones.

DO

- ✓ Ask open questions, then wait
- ✓ Use silent writing and round-robins
- ✓ Speak last in discussions

SAY

"What are we missing?"

"Who sees this differently?"

3 Respond Productively

WHAT YOU DO NEXT DECIDES IT

How you react to bad news, questions and failure tells people whether to speak again.

DO

- ✓ Thank people for raising problems
- ✓ Treat failure as learning: ask what happened
- ✓ Still address real misconduct, fairly

SAY

"Thank you for telling me early."

"What can we learn from this?"

4 Safety and Standards

SAFETY IS NOT THE SAME AS COMFORT

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY →

Comfort Zone
Safe, but little is asked of people

Learning Zone
Safe to speak up, and high standards: aim here

Apathy Zone
Not safe, and little expected

Anxiety Zone
High pressure, but unsafe to speak up

LOW STANDARDS — ACCOUNTABILITY → — HIGH STANDARDS

5 Phrases to Use and Avoid

TRY SAYING	AVOID SAYING
"What would you do?"	*"Who's responsible for this?"*
"Help me understand."	*"That's not how we do it here."*
"What did we learn?"	*"Why didn't you tell me sooner?"*
"I'd value your view on this."	*"Any questions? No? Good."*
"Thanks for flagging that."	*"Just make it work."*
"Let's look at the process, not the person."	*"I don't want problems, I want solutions."*

6 Daily Habits

SMALL, REPEATED, VISIBLE

- ☐ Open meetings by asking for risks and concerns
- ☐ Close decisions with a fist of five
- ☐ Ask the quietest person first, sometimes
- ☐ Admit a mistake or a doubt each week
- ☐ Thank the person who brings the hardest news
- ☐ Follow up on what people raised

7 Warning Signs

TIME TO ACT

- Meetings go quiet when you speak
- Bad news reaches you late, or second-hand
- Status is always green
- No one asks questions or disagrees

"When did someone last tell you something you didn't want to hear, and how did you react?"

"What would make it easier to say "I don't know" here?"

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